

Primary Health Care (PHC)

The Big Picture

PHC = **essential health care, universally accessible, at affordable cost, with full community participation** — the route to "**Health for All.**" Launched at the **Alma-Ata Declaration (1978)**, it shifts from a narrow medical/cure model to **prevention + promotion + community + intersectoral action**. Reaffirmed by the **Astana Declaration (2018)** and central to **Universal Health Coverage + SDGs**.

Defining Health

- **WHO (1948):** "a state of complete **physical, mental and social well-being**, not merely the absence of disease."
- Highest attainable standard of health = a **fundamental right** of every human.

Alma-Ata Declaration (1978)

- Adopted at the International Conference on PHC, **Alma-Ata, Kazakhstan, 6–12 Sept 1978**.
- **First international declaration** on the importance of PHC; urged urgent action by all governments for "Health for All."

Definition of PHC (Alma-Ata)

"Essential health care based on **practical, scientifically sound and socially acceptable methods and technology**, made **universally accessible** to individuals and families through their **full participation** and at a **cost the community and country can afford**, in the spirit of **self-reliance and self-determination**."

Medical Model vs PHC (the shift)

Medical model	PHC
Treatment	**Health promotion**
Cure	**Prevention + care + cure**
Episodic care	**Continuous care**
Specific problems	**Comprehensive care**
Professional dominance	**Community participation**
Health sector alone	**Intersectoral collaboration**

Principles of PHC (4)

1. **Equitable distribution** (accessible to all).
2. **Community participation**.
3. **Intersectoral coordination**.
4. **Appropriate technology** (affordable, acceptable).

Strategies (Alma-Ata)

1. Develop a basic **health infrastructure**.
2. **Two-way referral system** between service levels.
3. Develop **human resources** for health.
4. Incorporate **traditional medicine**.
5. Ensure **intersectoral cooperation**.

Elements of PHC (the classic list)

Health **education**, **nutrition** (food supply), **safe water + sanitation**, **maternal & child health + family planning**, **immunization**, **prevention/control of endemic diseases**, **treatment of common diseases/injuries**, **essential drugs** (+ mental health, dental in expanded lists).

Levels of Prevention (role of PHC)

- **Primary** — prevent disease occurring (immunisation, health education, sanitation).
- **Secondary** — early detection + treatment (**screening**).
- **Tertiary** — limit disability + **rehabilitation**.
- Key economic argument: **\$1 in prevention saves much in treatment**.

Obstacles to PHC Progress

Lack of political commitment/funding, inadequate infrastructure + workforce, poor community participation, weak intersectoral coordination, poverty, conflict.

Astana Declaration (2018)

Reaffirmed Alma-Ata; PHC as the cornerstone of **Universal Health Coverage (UHC)** and the **Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)**; emphasises empowered people + communities, and integrated services.

Walk-Away Points

- PHC = **essential, universally accessible, affordable, community-participatory** care = route to **Health for All**.
- **Alma-Ata 1978** birthed it; **Astana 2018** reaffirmed it (→ UHC + SDGs).
- **4 principles**: equity, community participation, intersectoral coordination, appropriate technology.
- Elements = **education, nutrition, water/sanitation, MCH/family planning, immunisation, endemic disease control, treatment, essential drugs**.
- Prevention levels: **primary (prevent), secondary (screen), tertiary (rehab)**.